Trump Pauses Russia Sanctions, Drawing Criticism From Both Parties

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President Donald Trump has paused a number of **sanctions** on Russia just two days before they were set to begin. **Sanctions** are penalties, such as limits on money and trade, that countries use to pressure another country to change its actions.

The **sanctions** were passed by the US Congress and signed into law by Trump in September. They were meant to put pressure on Russia over its war in Ukraine. The law also targeted senior Russian figures, including President Vladimir Putin, as well as Russian banks and a group of ships that Russia uses to get around existing trade limits.

On Friday night, Trump signed an **executive order** saying that suspending some of the **sanctions** was in the US **national interest**. Secretary of State Marco Rubio said the pause would last 60 days, so the administration can study how the **sanctions** might affect the US and world economy.

Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelensky said it was unfortunate that the US decided to "completely **disregard**" the **sanctions**. He said they "could have helped enormously" in pressuring Russia to end the war. He also said Russian attacks overnight had hit 15 Ukrainian energy sites, causing power cuts in several regions.

A Russian **envoy**, Kirill Dmitriev, praised Trump's order. He said the **sanctions** would have caused "serious damage" to the US and global markets.

The decision drew criticism from lawmakers in both major US parties. Democrats such as Virginia Congressman Don Beyer said Trump was turning his back on Ukraine. Some Republicans also disagreed. Texas Senator Ted Cruz called it a mistake, and Texas Senator John Cornyn called it "reckless."

Relations between the US and Ukraine were already tense. Last week, the US agreed to a deal to **import** Russian diesel fuel, and Ukraine has accused the Trump administration of withdrawing key military support.

Word Treasure

sanctions -- Penalties, such as limits on trade or money, that countries use to pressure another country.

executive order -- A rule a president issues directly, without Congress passing a new law.

national interest -- What a government believes is best for its own country.

disregard -- To ignore something or treat it as unimportant.

envoy -- A person sent to represent a country in talks with others.

import -- To bring goods into a country from another country.

Background you need

Russia invaded Ukraine, and the two countries have been at war, with Ukraine asking other nations for help.

Sanctions are a tool countries use instead of fighting: they limit trade, banking or travel to put economic pressure on a government.

In the United States, Congress can pass sanctions as a law, while the president leads foreign policy and can issue executive orders.

Because Congress had passed these sanctions as a law, pausing them caused disagreement with many lawmakers.

Break it down

LEAD: Trump paused several Russia sanctions two days before they would start
KEY EVENT: Executive order signed Friday night suspending some sanctions
+- WHO: President Donald Trump; Secretary of State Marco Rubio
+- WHAT: A 60-day pause to study effects on the US and world economy
+- TARGETS: Senior Russian figures, Russian banks and ships that get around trade limits
REACTIONS: Zelensky calls it unfortunate; Russian envoy Dmitriev praises it; lawmakers in both parties object
CONTEXT: US-Ukraine relations already tense after a Russian diesel import deal
OPEN QUESTION: What will happen after the 60-day review?

Why it matters

The decision shows how a president can change how a law passed by Congress is carried out, and it affects the pressure on Russia over its war in Ukraine.

Test what you remember

1. How long did Secretary of State Marco Rubio say the pause would last?

- (A) Six months
- (B) 60 days
- (C) Until the war ends
- (D) 30 days

2. When were the sanctions signed into law?

- (A) Last week
- (B) On Friday night
- (C) In January
- (D) In September

3. How many Ukrainian energy sites did Zelensky say were hit in overnight attacks?

- (A) 50
- (B) 5
- (C) 10
- (D) 15

4. Who praised Trump's order?

- (A) Russian envoy Kirill Dmitriev
- (B) Congressman Don Beyer
- (C) Senator Ted Cruz
- (D) President Volodymyr Zelensky

5. Which word did Senator John Cornyn use to describe the move?

- (A) Smart
- (B) Reckless
- (C) Necessary
- (D) Historic

6. What deal did the US agree to last week?

- (A) A deal to sell planes to Ukraine
- (B) A deal to end the war
- (C) A deal to build new ships
- (D) A deal to import Russian diesel fuel

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: D 4: A 5: B 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Trump administration: Says pausing some sanctions is in the US national interest and wants 60 days to study the economic effects.

2. Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelensky: Says the sanctions could have helped enormously to pressure Russia to end the war.

3. Russian envoy Kirill Dmitriev: Praised the order and said the sanctions would have caused serious damage to markets.

4. Critics in Congress: Democrats such as Don Beyer and Republicans such as Ted Cruz and John Cornyn opposed the pause.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):